

Glossary

algorithm

A set of step-by-step instructions followed when performing a task: for example, by a computer program.

ASCII

“American Standard Code for Information Interchange”—a code used for storing text characters as binary code.

binary code

A way of writing numbers and data that uses only 0s and 1s.

bit

A binary digit—0 or 1. The smallest unit of digital information.

Boolean expression

A question that has only two possible answers, such as “true” and “false”.

branch

A point in a program where two different options are available to choose from.

bug

An error in a program’s code that makes it behave in an unexpected way.

byte

A unit of digital information that contains eight bits.

call

To use a function in a program.

compression

A way of making data smaller so that it takes up less storage space.

computer network

A way to link two or more computers together.

container

A part of a program that can be used to store a number of other data items.

data

Information, such as text, symbols, and numerical values.

debug

To look for and correct errors in a program.

debugger

A program that checks other programs for errors in their code.

directory

A place to store files to keep them organized.

encryption

A way of encoding data so that only certain people can read or access it.

event

Something a computer program can react to, such as a key being pressed or the mouse being clicked.

execute

See *run*.

file

A collection of data stored with a name.

float

A number with a decimal point in it.

function

A piece of code that does part of a larger task.

gate

Used by computers to make decisions. Gates use one or more input signals to produce an output signal, based on a rule. For example, “AND” gates produce a positive output only when both input signals are positive. Other gates include “OR” and “NOT”.

GPU

A graphics processing unit (GPU) allows images to be displayed on a computer screen.

graphics

Visual elements on a screen that are not text, such as pictures, icons, and symbols.

GUI

The GUI, or graphical user interface, is the name for the buttons and windows that make up the part of the program you can see and interact with.

hacker

A person who breaks into a computer system. “White hat” hackers work for computer security companies and look for problems in order to fix them. “Black hat” hackers break into computer systems to cause harm or to make profit from them.

hardware

The physical parts of a computer that you can see or touch, such as wires, the keyboard, and the display screen.

hexadecimal

A number system based on 16, where the numbers 10 to 15 are represented by the letters A to F.

index number

A number given to an item in a list. In Python, the index number of the first item will be 0, the second item 1, and so on.

input

Data that is entered into a computer: for example, from a microphone, keyboard, or mouse.